

Beyond the Manuscripts and Microscopes

Experimenting with effective #SciComm

Leen Sevens





Introduction

All these people really seem to have it together,
and I still have no idea what's going on.





What communication channels have you used in the past to communicate about your research?

Written social media (X, LinkedIn,...)

0%

Blogs/articles on science communication websites

0%

Video & audio (YouTube, TikTok, podcasts,...)

0%

Pitch competitions (Falling Walls Lab, 3 Minute Thesis, Flemish PhD Cup,...)

0%

Festivals & events (Science Day, Children's University, Nerdland,...)

0%

Directly reaching out to the media or press office

0%

Visiting a school/library/museum/... to talk about my research

0%

None!

0%



1. Know your audience

Know your
audience.



**HEY AUDIENCE!
WHO THE HELL
ARE YOU?!**

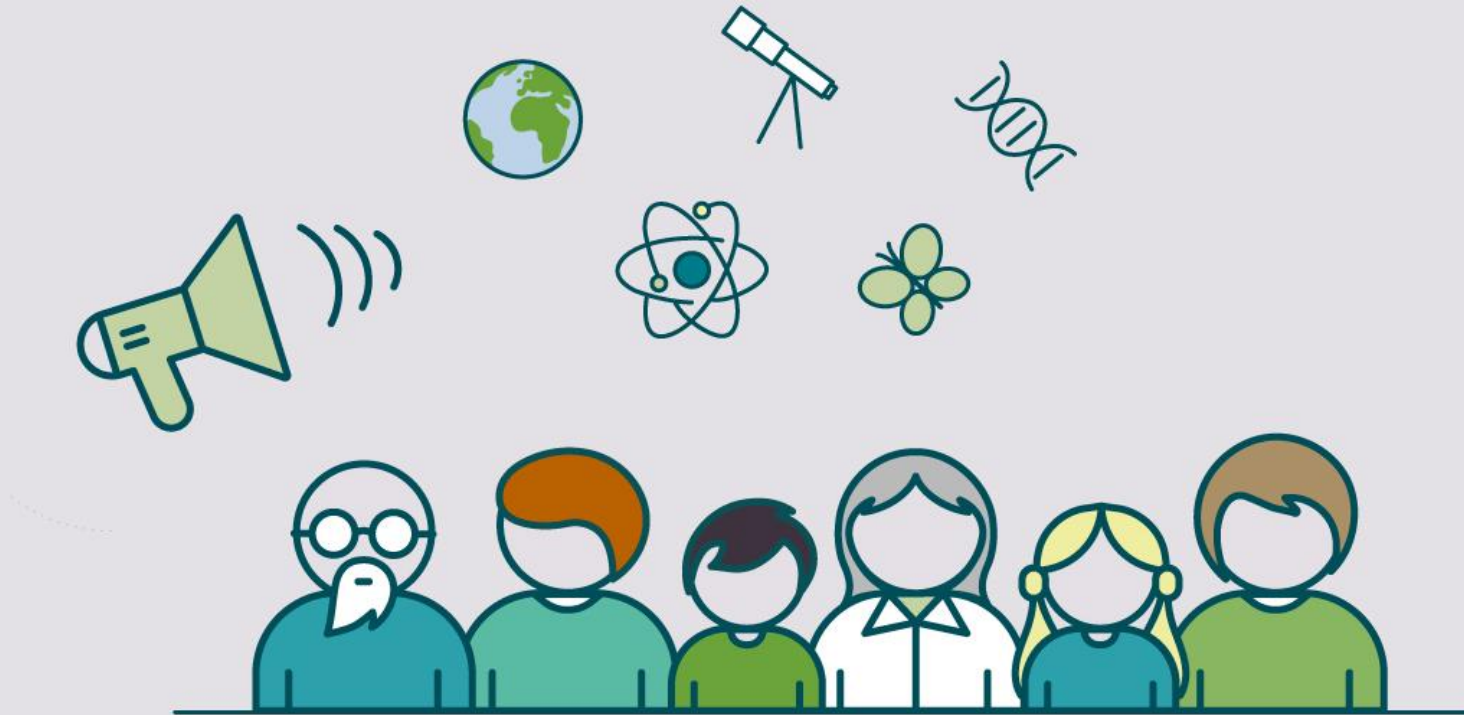


CHIRP CHIRP CHIRP CHIRP

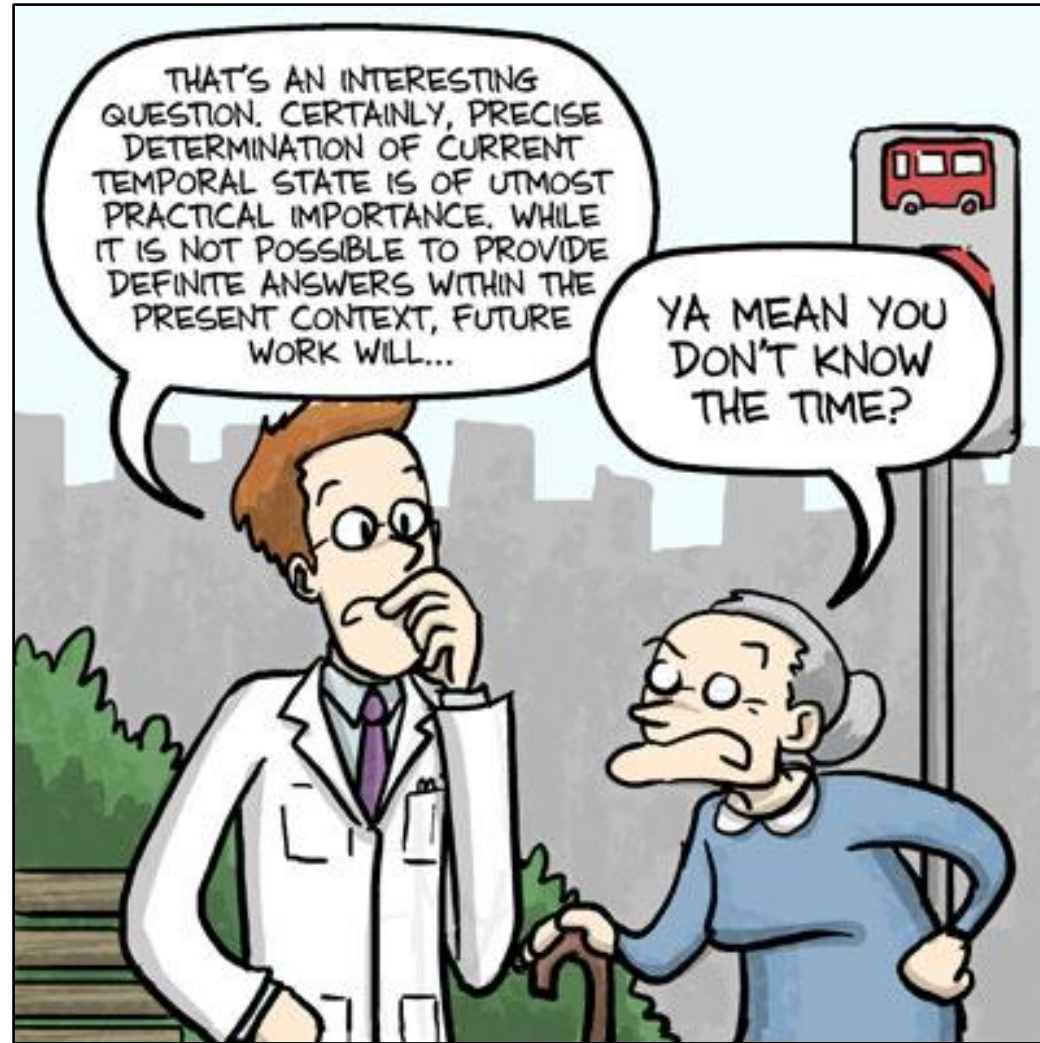


ALL
ABOUT
CRICKETS





2. Don't use jargon



Terms that have different meanings for scientists and the public

Scientific term	Public meaning	Better choice
enhance	improve	intensify, increase
aerosol	spray can	tiny atmospheric particle
positive trend	good trend	upward trend
positive feedback	good response, praise	vicious cycle, self-reinforcing cycle
theory	hunch, speculation	scientific understanding
uncertainty	ignorance	range
error	mistake, wrong, incorrect	difference from exact true number
bias	distortion, political motive	offset from an observation
sign	indication, astrological sign	plus or minus sign
values	ethics, monetary value	numbers, quantity
manipulation	illicit tampering	scientific data processing
scheme	devious plot	systematic plan
anomaly	abnormal occurrence	change from long-term average

Physics Today, October 2011 (Richard Somerville and Susan Hassol)



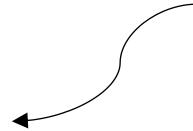
3. Use social media

Written Social Media (X/LinkedIn/...)

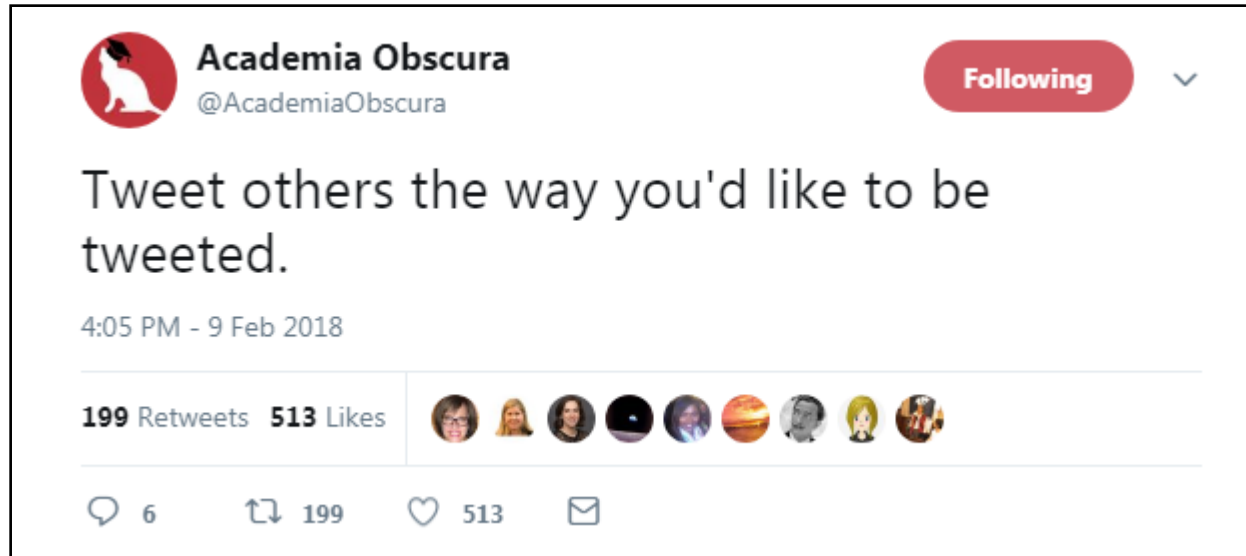
Create an account, connect, and start sharing!

#AcademicChatter
#AcademicTwitter
#ScienceCommunication, #SciComm
#ScienceOutreach
#SciencelsAwesome
#PhDAdvice
#WomeninSTEM, #WomenInScience
#AcademicMentalHealth, #AcademicSelfcare
#Linguistics, #Psychology, #Law, #EconTwitter,...

Useful hashtags



The basic rules...



Writer's block?

- Live-tweet conferences, talks and other events (like this one!)
- Direct message people you want to interview, talk to and/or brainstorm with
- Share things you find inspiring
- Offer to answer questions related to particular topics
- Rant and talk about life as a scientist and science communicator



Need inspiration?
The #ThesisThread Competition

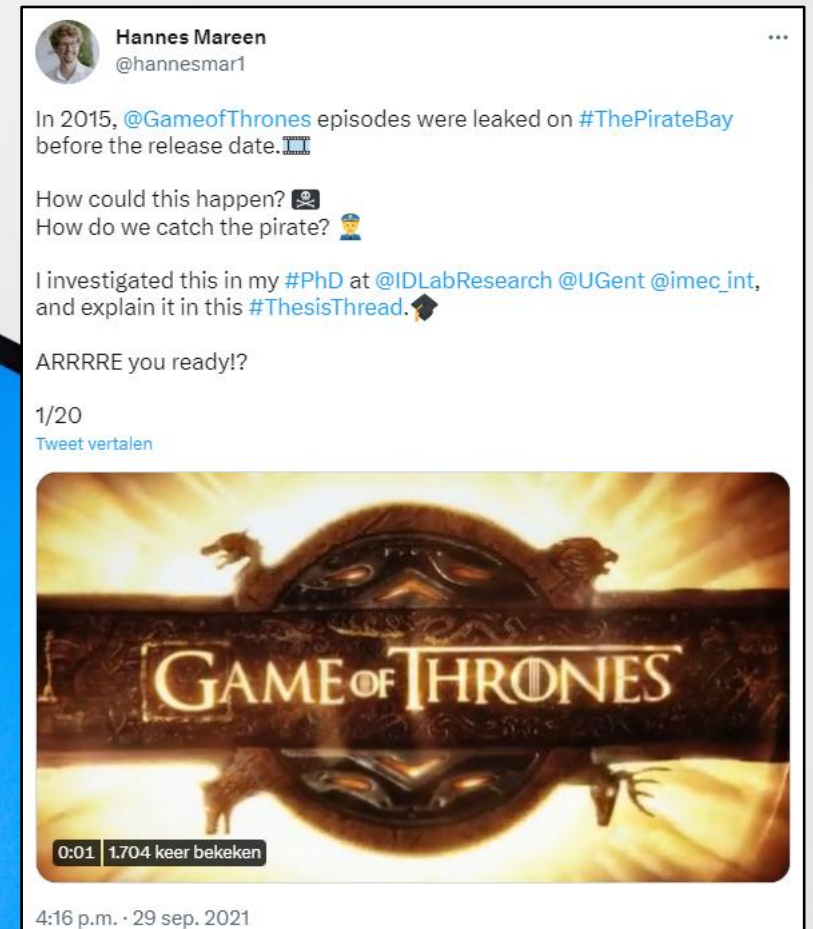
Who? Last-year PhDs &
PhDs who have defended in
the past 6 months

Language? English or Dutch

When? TBD

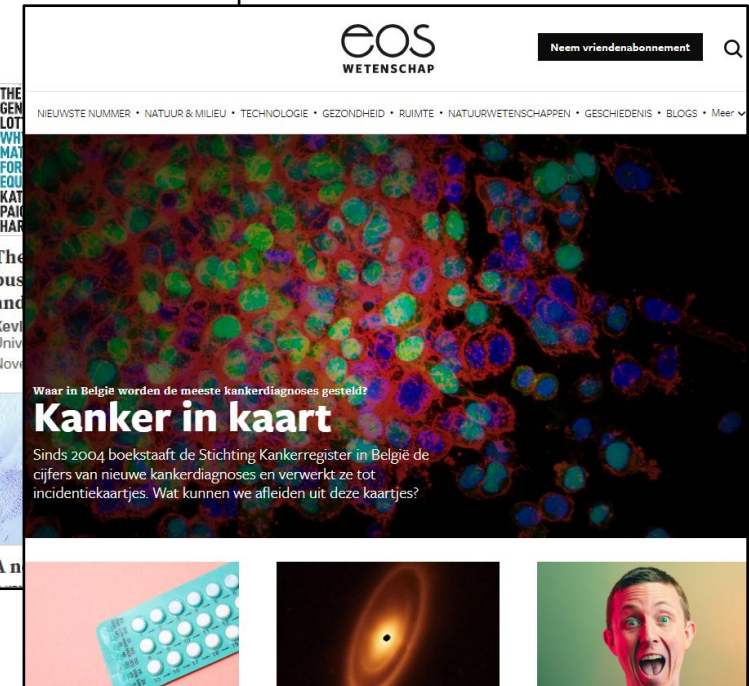
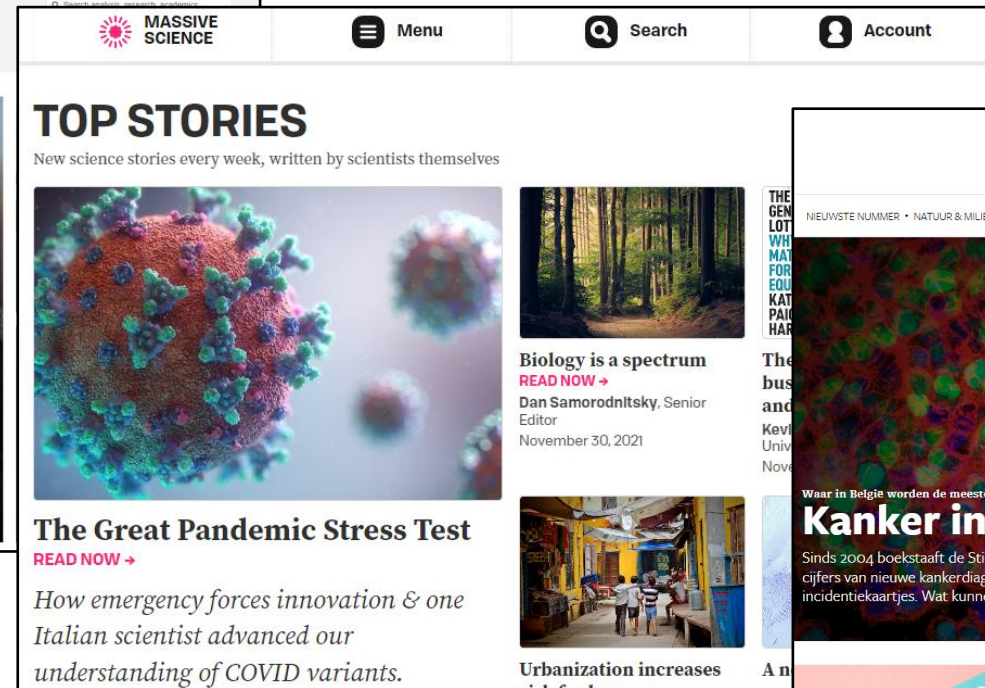
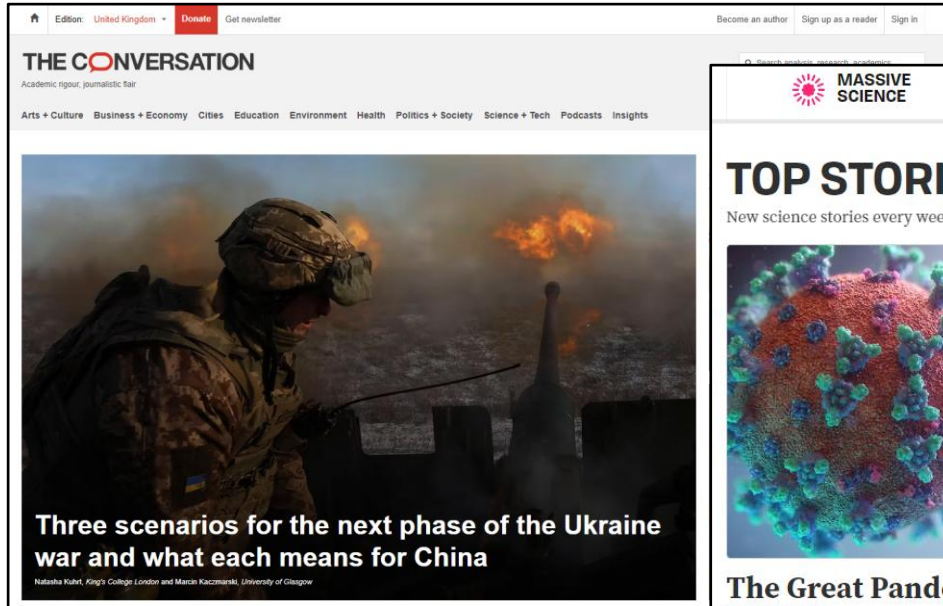
URL?

<https://vlir.be/events/thesis-thread-2022/>



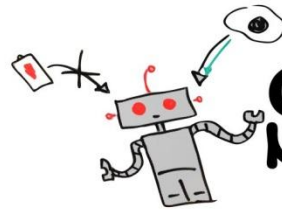
Blogs & science communication websites

Publish an article on The Conversation, Massive Science, The Science Breaker, EOS Magazine,...



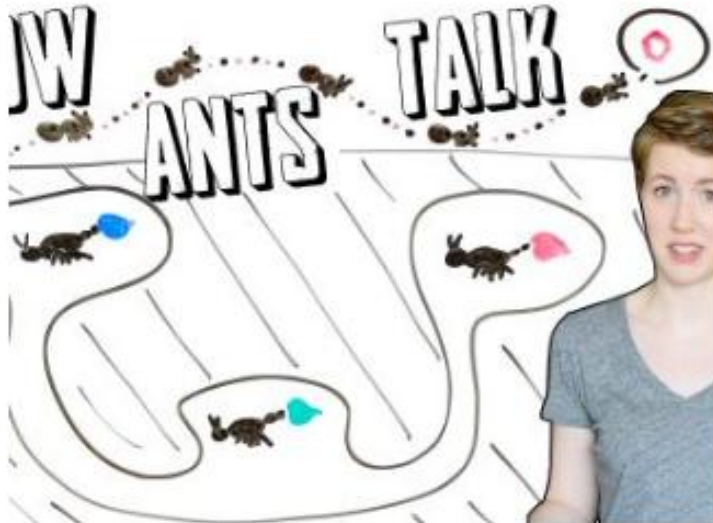
Video & Audio (YouTube/TikTok/Spotify/...)

Create your own science videos and podcasts!



SimpleBiologist

Just like Kate!

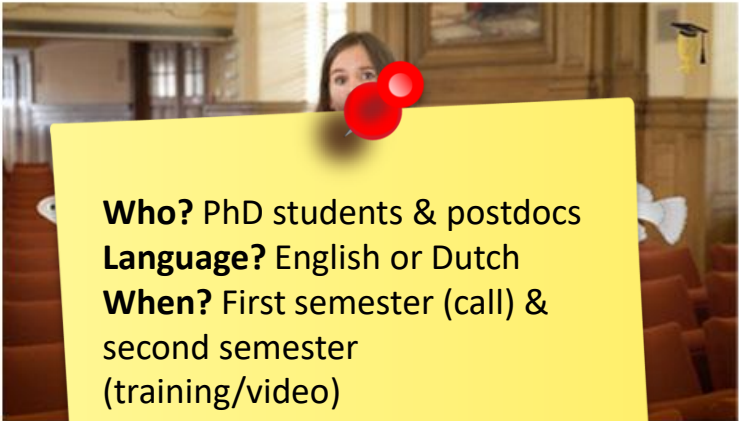


The MutAnts are Here

Posted on [August 27, 2017](#)

Have you ever seen ants walking in a line and wondered how they do it? Scientists have known for a long time that ants use secreted chemicals called pheromones to [...]

[READ MORE](#)



Who? PhD students & postdocs
Language? English or Dutch
When? First semester (call) & second semester (training/video)
URL?

<https://www.sciencefiguredout.be/>
<https://www.wetenschapuitgedokterd.be>



Kulak Spotlight!
Wouter Deleersnyder

Need a little push?
Wetenschap Uitgedokterd
(Science Figured Out)



Kulak Spotlight!
Mila Marinova





4. Use your talents

STEM HEROES



Created by

Ana Verissimo

Illustrated by

Eri Mine

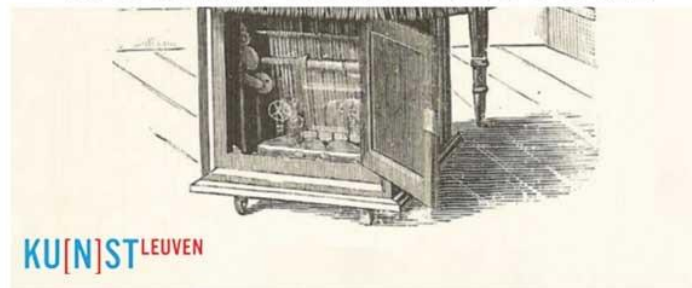
Japanese translation by

Liv & Anna Nakamura

Frascati Symphonic & Frascati Vocal presenteren
5-12-2014 / 20.30 **LEUVEN**
€ 35 www.frascatismphonic.com



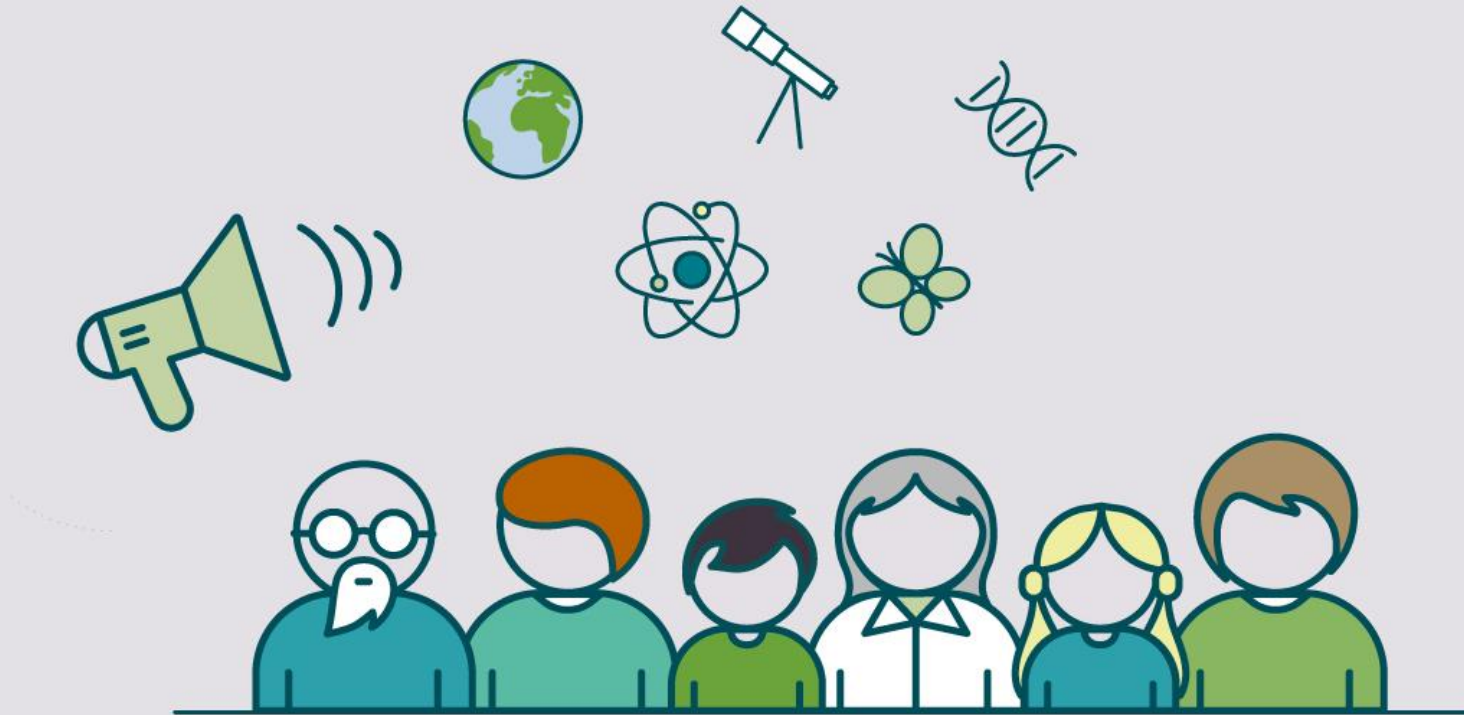
CASPARO A COMIC SCIENCE OPERA



VU: 1 Muziek Frascati VZW, Kris Smeets



KU[N]ST LEUVEN



5. Learn the basics of effective presentation strategies



საპარლამენტო ბიბლიოთეკა
საპარლამენტო ბიბლიოთეკა

საპარლამენტო ბიბლიოთეკა
საპარლამენტო ბიბლიოთეკა
საპარლამენტო ბიბლიოთეკა

საპარლამენტო ბიბლიოთეკა

საპარლამენტო ბიბლიოთეკა



65%

of the population
are visual learners



90%

information transmitted
to the brain is visual





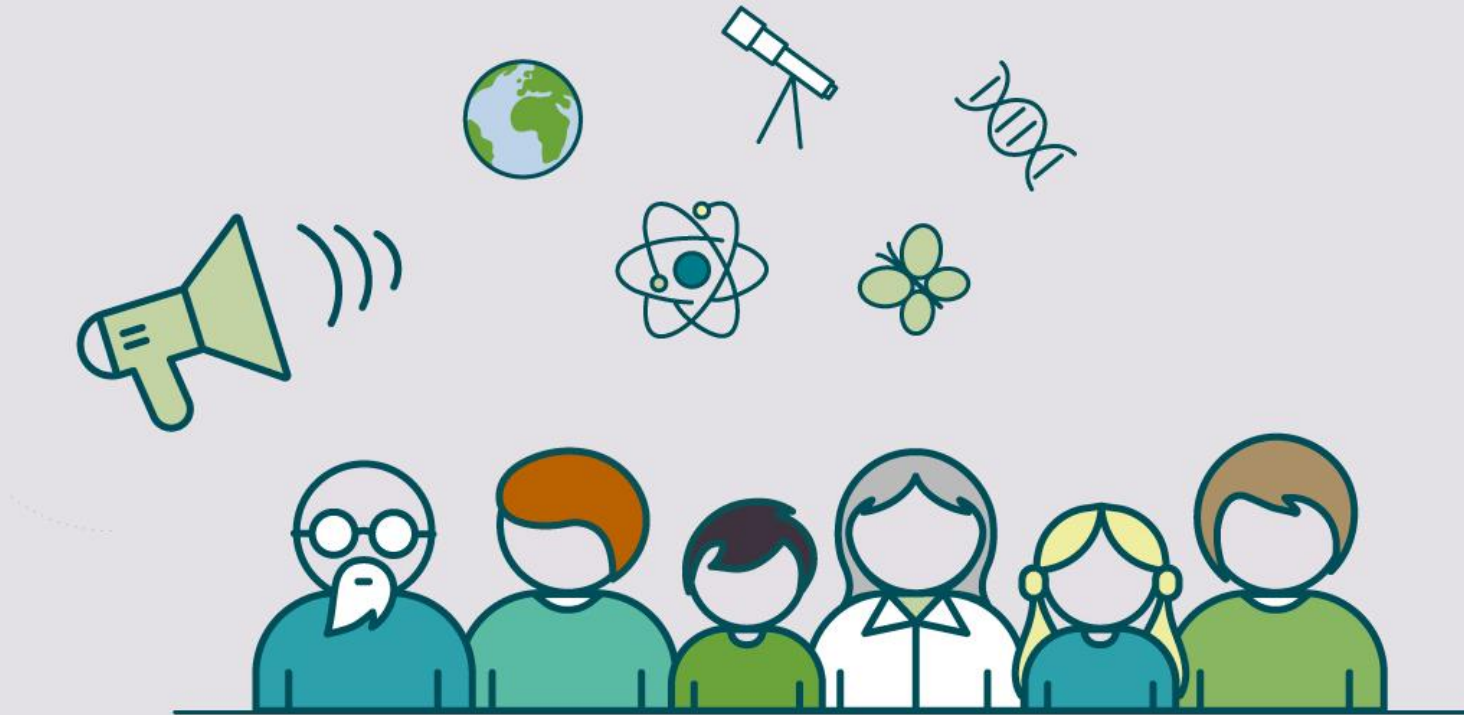
Learn more about science communication strategies at:



<https://www.scicomm-academy.eu/>



<https://www.letstalkscience.be/>



6. Participate in a pitch competition

Falling Walls Lab

Pitch your research in just 3 minutes!



Who? Students, researchers, postdocs, junior professors

Language? English

When? February (call & training) & March (competition)

URL?

<https://www.kuleuven.be/communicatie/wetenschapscommunicatie/voor-onderzoekers/falling-walls-lab/falling-walls-lab-for-candidates>

**FOR CREATORS,
INNOVATORS,
TRAILBLAZERS,
AND VISIONARIES**

De Vlaamse PhD Cup

Extensive media training & a 3-minute pitch

Kulak Spotlights!

Who? PhDs who have defended in the past two years

Language? Dutch

When? July (deadline for call) & October (training & competition)

URL? <https://www.phdcup.be/>



Sofie Claerhout



Pieter Senden



Chanelle Delameillieure

Three Minute Thesis

Pitch your research in – *guess what?* – 3 minutes!



Who? PhD students & postdocs

Language? English

When? November (call & competition)

URL?

<https://www.kuleuven.be/communicatie/wetenschapscommunicatie/voor-onderzoekers/3-minute-thesis/3MinuteThesis>

Wetenschapsbattle (Battle of the Scientists)

Making kids excited about your research



Who? All Researchers
Language? English, Dutch or French
When? November (call) & March (competition)
URL? <https://wetenschapsbattle.be/>

Kulak Spotlight!
Maarten Mees





7. Participate in events

Dag van de Wetenschap (Science Day)

Welcoming a broad audience to our “sacred” research grounds

Who? All researchers

Language? English or Dutch

When? August (deadline for call)
& 4th Sunday of November
(event)

URL's?

<https://www.kuleuven.be/brugge/nieuws/nieuws/Meer-dan-600-bezoekers-zakken-af-naar-ku-leuven-brugge-voor-dag-van-de-wetenschap>



Kinderuniversiteit

Making kids feel like a real university student for one day



Who? All researchers

Language? Dutch

When? October

URL?

https://kulak.kuleuven.be/nl/nieuws_activiteiten/nieuws/kinderuniversiteit-op-kulak-verwelkomt-heel-wat-ontdekkers

Nerland Festival

Geeks unite!

Who? All researchers

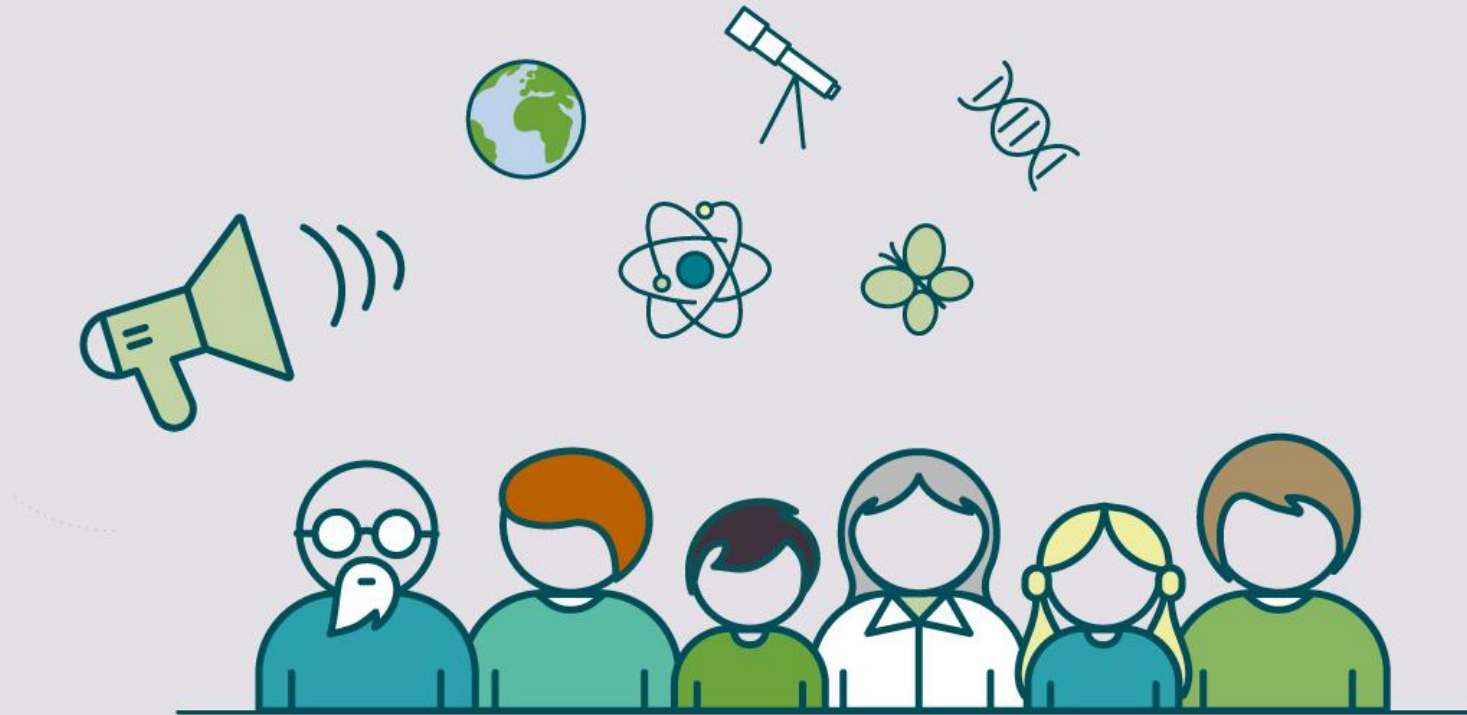
Language? Dutch

When? Autumn (call) & May (festival)

URL?

<https://www.nerdlandfestival.be/nl/>





8. Take matters into your own hands

Reach out to the media or the university's press office

A detailed illustration of a media scrum. In the foreground, a man with grey hair and glasses, wearing a dark blue jacket, is seen from the side, looking towards the center. He is surrounded by a dense crowd of people, many of whom are holding professional cameras and microphones. Some cameras are pointed directly at him, while others are angled towards the center of the scrum. The background is filled with more people, some holding cameras on tripods, and others holding microphones on boom poles. The overall scene depicts a high-pressure, high-attention media event.

Or for regional press,
please contact Petra
Huyst, head of
Research and External
Relations at Kulak:
petra.huyst@kuleuven.be



9. Be prepared for your media interview

Loads of
Information



Bare
Essence



21
shares

Leuvense illustratrice Leen Sevens (25): "Fantasie houdt mijn leven in balans"

29/01/2018 om 12:20 door Emily Nees / StampMedia - [Print](#) - [Corrigeer](#)



LEUVEN



PVDA wil sneller meer sociale woningen:
"Wachtlijst zal aan dit tempo pas over 74 j...



Populaire The Empty shop komt naar Leuven

AL HET NIEUWS UIT LEUVEN

Pagina leuk vinden

N+ ENKEL VOOR ABONNEES





Conclusions



Take-home messages

- The perfect science communication activity for you is the one that you enjoy, that you are good at and that people like you to do
- Be patient, it takes time both to find your voice and to build an audience
- Don't be afraid to promote your work on social media or in your workplace
- Just do it, all it often takes is just a tiny bit of courage!



Thank you!

leen.sevens@kuleuven.be
@leensevens